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Sonoma State president Mike Lee supported Israel divestment, boycott. Now he's retiring

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Sonoma State University president Mike Lee announced Thursday that he will retire after he was placed on administrative leave for "insubordination." Lee had previously committed to supporting SSU student protesters calling on the university to boycott and divest from Israel.

In a Tuesday email to students at the university, Lee responded to student protesters' demands about the university's financial ties to Israel amid the war in Gaza, where more than 35,000 Palestinians have died in the months since Hamas attacked Israel on Oct. 7, killing more 1,200 people.

In the email, Lee said he met with students and faculty participating in the campus occupation between May 10 and May 14, where they all reached several agreements on the protesters' various demands.

Students began protesting at the California State University campus in Rohnert Park on April 26, one of many college campuses in California to do so. They set up tents on Person Lawn, occupying campus space to demand that SSU administration disclose financial ties to Israel, boycott Israeli universities, introduce historic curriculum about Palestine and recognize Palestinian identity, and support a permanent cease fire in Gaza.

Lee's agreement with students included the creation of the Advisory Council of Students for Justice in Palestine. Lee also committed to "launching research on and a review of all SSU Foundation investments," to be released fall 2024. SSU administration and the SJP Advisory Council "will meet with proper officials to determine a course of action leading to divestment strategies that include seeking ethical alternatives," Lee wrote.

He also committed to an academic boycott of Israeli universities.

But the chancellor of the CSU system issued a swift response, putting Lee on leave almost immediately.

Lee's message "was sent without the appropriate approvals," said CSU Chancellor Mildred García in a statement Wednesday.

"Because of this insubordination and consequences it has brought upon the system, President Lee has been placed on administrative leave."

Lee sent a follow-up statement Wednesday, expressing his regret about his initial letter, and confirming that he did not consult the Chancellor or the CSU system before sending it.

MIKE-LEE-MUG.jpgMike Lee, Sonoma State's president, was placed on leave Wednesday, May 15, 2024, following an email to students announcing a pact with pro-Palestinian protesters on campus. One demand that the school had agreed to was a boycott of collaborations that are "sponsored by, or represent, the Israeli state academic and research institutions."

"In my attempt to find agreement with one group of students, I marginalized other members of our student population and community," he said. "I realize the harm that this has caused, and I take full ownership of it. I deeply regret the unintended consequences of my actions.

Lee, a former Sacramento State professor and administrator who took the role of interim president at SSU in

November 2022, said he will use his time on leave “to reflect on the harm this has caused and will be working with the Chancellor’s Office to determine next steps.”

The next step for Lee is his retirement, according to a Thursday statement from García.

“I thank President Lee for his years of service to the California State University — starting at California State University, Sacramento — and to higher education overall,” she wrote. “I wish him and his family well.”

California lawmakers respond

Local lawmakers and members of the Jewish Legislative Caucus were pleased with García’s decision to place Lee on leave.

“His endorsement of an academic boycott was totally unacceptable and evidence that former President Lee is unfit to lead one of our great state institutions,” said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, D-Encino, and Sen. Scott Wiener, D-San Francisco, co-chairs of the Jewish Caucus.

“We look forward to working with Chancellor García and the CSU Trustees to pursue a different path that will promote learning, respectful dialogue, mutual respect, inclusivity, and peace.”

Sen. Bill Dodd, D-Napa, also supported García’s “quick response” to Lee.

“We need stability and thoughtful leadership at Sonoma State.”

California Republicans have been outspoken in their disapproval of campus protests.

“Anyone harassing and assaulting students, taking over buildings, or blocking access to education on our state campuses should be arrested and removed. Period. Full stop. Where is the Governor?” Assembly Republican Leader James Gallagher, R-Yuba City wrote in a post on X.

Congressman Kevin Kiley, R-Rocklin, has said that all encampments should be shut down and introduced a resolution that would call on universities to work with local law enforcement to do so. He also called protesters “pro-Hamas.”

“Perhaps the only thing more disgraceful than illegal pro-Hamas encampments is the way some universities have catered to them,” Kiley said on May 7. “This Resolution calls on universities to uphold the law and enforce their rules, while protecting freedom of speech to the fullest extent.”

CSU-wide ramifications

Sonoma State has served as something of a cautionary tale for universities in the 23-campus CSU system.

CSU investments are centrally managed, and as of March 31 it had an $8.3 billion portfolio. But each individual campus has its own auxiliary funds with separate investment portfolios. So while the CSU at large has said it will not divest from Israel, campuses have some autonomy over their own auxiliary funds.

With the swift response to Lee’s attempt to divest, though, individual campuses may be less inclined to proceed in that direction.

Even at Sacramento State, where President Luke Wood made a similar decision on divestment May 8 — which ended on-campus protests — he was quick to follow up the next day with a message to students confirming that, while making changes that aligned with the protesters about “socially responsible investments,” the university “did not sign a treaty or agreement with students to close the encampment.”

“You sign a treaty with your enemies, not with your students,” he said. “We are proud that our students expressed their concerns peacefully and in accordance with our policies. The encampment didn’t disperse because the protesters saw our policies; they left because they saw our hearts.”

Wood also opened the campus’s Jewish Life and Resource Center the same day he announced his decision on divestment.

“Our goal is that we will be a choice institution for students across the world,” he said. “And particularly across the country who identify as Jewish and want to learn more about Jewish life and culture.”

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